



Media Centre on Windows 10

Windows Media Centre is available unofficially for Windows 10. Know more here: <http://dgit.in/MdiaCentre10>



The MagFridge

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Insight

African descent. Kenya alone makes up a third of the fastest times recorded for middle and long distance running events. Include runners from Ethiopia and this figure swells to more than 50 per cent. Kenya's Nandi district with its relatively tiny 500,000 population single hand-



Armstrong gesturing how much money he's going to make from the book deal

edly accounts for more than 20 per cent of distance running records. That's a genuinely staggering ratio of athletic talent distributed within a very small section of population.

Not surprisingly, caucasians are virtually absent from running leaderboards, especially in recent times. Prima facie, Bannister's claims have solid empirical evidence peppered throughout the annals of competitive sports. However, concrete evidence supporting the same was uncovered by researchers when they performed microscopic analysis of muscle fibre belonging to different races. The tests revealed that black, on an average, have significantly high amount of metabolically efficient fast-twitch muscle fibres compared to caucasians. In short, the unequivocally racist catchphrase "white men can't jump" has been proven by science itself.

Doping the parity away

The only thing that separates men from machines is how the latter is characterised by uniformity in performance. The situation is more or less the same at the upper echelons of competitive sports. There's little to no performance variation and success is largely determined more by racial predisposition than just hard work. Unlike machines, man knows how to game the system to its benefit.

There hasn't been a more prominent and egregious example than that of Lance Armstrong. After dominating the Tour de France for several years, the champion cyclist revealed on Oprah that he had been using EPO to significantly increase performance and endurance. What's more

interesting is that Armstrong was never caught by anti-doping watchdogs despite steamrolling through Tour de France wins. Manufacturing a sensation to sell his book was about the only real reason why he was willing to forego his Tour de France medals. That sure sounds like a win-win scenario.

Instances such as these have prompted the sports fraternity to establish agencies such as World Anti-Doping Agency in 2000. All sportsmen competing in major athletic tournaments are tested rigorously; nevertheless, the number of athletes failing the tests still comes down to 1 to 2 per cent, annually. If these are athletes that are bad at hiding, how many are getting away with it? Based on a survey, an estimated 14 to 39 per cent athletes have admitted to doping undetected. It is a huge industry and those who mess with the system enroll the help of medical professionals and pharmacologists, who employ advanced test evading tactics such as micro-dosing to prevent detection.

Excellence through engineering

This rather disturbing revelation brings the athletes back to square one. If practically everyone's taking performance enhancing drugs, the parity has been established all over again. How exactly does an athlete go about getting the decisive edge over his evenly matched opponent? Through the same force of human excellence that has delivered us from extinction time and again – through the noble pursuit of engineering. This is really where the concept of human machines comes into its own.

Take the example of Oscar Pistorius. The South African athlete had both his legs amputated below the knee when he was barely a year old. The prosthetic limbs tailor-made for Pistorius not only allowed him to move about, but they allowed him to achieve something that most able bodied men can only dream of: Olympic glory. The prosthetic feet used by the disabled athlete embodied several generations of research and development in the fields of biomechanics augmented with the latest in exotic engineering materials. Comprised of carbon-fibre reinforced polymer materials, Flex-Foot Cheetah prosthetic feet endowed Pistorius with the sort of running ability that able bodied men could only envy.

In fact, Pistorius' clean sweep of paralympics and the global recognition that it earned the "blade runner" led to a string of inquisitions and later bans arising out of accusations that the prosthetics gave him an unfair advantage over able bodied athletes. Irrespective controversy, Pistorius went on to dominate paralympics,



Oscar Pistorius was the first amputee to compete with able bodied athletes

as well as to become the first amputee to compete regular Olympics.

Science to the Rescue

You don't have to be disabled to benefit from the multitudes of leaps and advances in the fields of sports technology. State-of-the-art Modern computer aided diagnostic tools provide accurate performance measurement tools and advances in biomechanical analysis allow athletes to learn and correct any extant mistakes with their